Hardware — atoms are expensive, evidence doesn’t have to be

What changes: iteration cycles cost weeks and money, so you buy MORE evidence before building, not less. Juicero (M00 case) is your founding myth — $120M of hardware, €0 of demand testing. Never be the pedestal.

Your wallet-equivalents: deposits (€50 refundable counts — it’s real commitment), pre-orders at real price, paid design-partnerships with the first B2B users. Crowdfunding pledges count as validation WITH the caveat: campaign traffic you bought ≠ organic demand.

Your ladder translation: M04 → landing page with PRE-ORDER button at the real intended price (click-to-preorder rate is your threshold, even if you don’t charge yet — but charging deposits beats everything). M05/M06 → looks-like/works-like split: a 3D-print + Wizard-of-Oz electronics is a legitimate prototype; McDonald’s chalk lines (M06) are your spirit animal. M08 → sell deposits, hand-deliver the first units yourself. M09 pricing → BOM is your floor, value is your price; never price from cost.

Your traps: tooling/certification before demand, “we need €50k before we can test anything” (you don’t — you need a render and 20 conversations), confusing maker-community applause with customers.

Kill criteria that bite: preorder conversion < 2% on target-segment traffic · nobody accepts a paid deposit after 10 asks · BOM math can’t reach a viable margin even at scale assumptions you’d defend in a tribunal.